

Rep. Tom Emmer on Squawk Box

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BECKY:

House Republicans are looking to defend their narrow majority heading into the midterms, even as the economy weighs heavily on American voters' minds. Joining us right now to talk about the Republican agenda and the midterms is House Majority Whip Congressman Tom Emmer. And Congressman, thank you for being with us this morning. Let's talk a little bit about what you're seeing. We did see the action on the continuing resolution to make sure that we fund the government through December 11th, but it came, you needed a couple of Democrats to vote along with that. I think there were five Republicans who did not vote in favor of that. What does that tell you about where we stand and what else you can get done in terms of your agenda before the midterms?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, good morning, Becky. It didn't show us anything that we haven't seen already, which is House Republicans are getting things done. It was brought on suspension because we had to find out, are Democrats in the House going to support the CR? But you're talking about something separate from the CR. You're talking about a bill, a compilation of bills that needed a procedural tool to move them across the floor. We never have complete agreement on procedural stuff. You're right. There were two Democrats that crossed over and voted for it because they knew that it was the right thing to do. But what's the Republican agenda? You've got to separate out the House and the Senate. The House has done its work, Becky. We not only passed the CR. The only reason the Senate, by the way, gave us a CR, a continuing resolution, is because we passed one before we left in July. Otherwise, we wouldn't have that right now. So the House has done its work. We've sent the clarity bill over there, which is a digital assets market structure bill. We sent it over more than a year ago, Becky, with almost 100 Democrat votes. And it sits over in the Senate, languishes. Reconciliation 3.0 was passed and is sent over there. The NDAA, the National Defense Authorization Act, was sent. It sits over there. So the House has done its work. Our members have a lot to run on.

BECKY:

What's wrong with the Senate?

REP. TOM EMMER:

You're going to have to ask the Senate. The House has passed close to 800 pieces of legislation. Over 500, maybe close to 600, still sit in the Senate without action. And I just gave you three of the biggest ones. I mean, the Senate's got to pass a farm bill. The House has done that. The Senate's got to get the work done. They're coming back in just over a week, and I'm hopeful that they're going to move a bunch of this stuff so that the House, if we need to take action, can take action on the things that really matter for the American people, and the president can sign them.

BECKY:

Congressman, right now, both the House and the Senate are controlled by the Republican majority. If it's hard to get work done between two Republican-controlled parties with a Republican president, what happens if the House, if you lose the majority in the House in this upcoming election?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, that's not accurate, Becky. In fact, the Senate, I would argue, is controlled by the Democrat, socialist, communist minority. Because of the filibuster, literally, they can stop anything that the Republicans are trying to do. It's the way it was set up by the Founding Fathers to make sure that there was...

BECKY:

It was not set up that way. That is not accurate, Becky. Becky, that's not accurate. This is not a product of the Founding Fathers. This is a product from many decades ago that the Senate just decided to do this. Do you realize, I don't think the American public does, that when it comes to reconciliation, for instance, which goes to the Senate parliamentarian, that the Senate parliamentarian can drop out things that they say it's the bird rule, a inside-the-beltway term. They can drop things out that they say are not income or expense. Well, guess what? The Senate, the Republican Senate, can actually overrule the parliamentarian with 50 plus one votes. Nobody seems to talk about that. The Republicans can move what they need to move over in the Senate. They just need to get it going.

BECKY:

Are you arguing to get rid of the filibuster, though? Tom, seriously, are you arguing to get rid of the filibuster?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I've said they should. I'm on record already. They should get rid of the filibuster.

BECKY:

So you just want it gone?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Becky, you were going to ask me what happens when the communists, if they ever come into control, they've already said they're getting rid of the filibuster. They're going to pack the court. They're going to create new states with a District of Columbia included. They've already made it clear what they're going to do. They are going to get rid of the filibuster. Look, Republicans in the Senate, I respect their right to make whatever decision they want. You ask me about the House, the House has done its work and the House will continue to do its work.

BECKY:

But you don't worry about those things? You think really getting rid of the filibuster and allowing whatever party's in control to just do anything? I mean, there's a reason that a lot of your Republican Senate colleagues have not wanted to get rid of that filibuster.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, I mean, I'll let them worry about that. From the House standpoint, it's extremely frustrating when you have a president who's moving an agenda that 77 million Americans voted for. Great example is the Save America Act. I mean, almost 80% of this country, Republican, Democrat, other, believe that it's reasonable to have to

establish that you are a U.S. citizen in order to exercise your right to vote and that when you show up to vote, you should have a photo ID. Yet, for some reason, they don't want to move that because it's not enough Americans have supported it. For the House, it's very frustrating when you have 80% issues like that that just sit and languish. And I was starting to tell you that digital assets bill, the Clarity Act, that had almost 100 Democrats in the House vote for it. It should have been moved long ago.

BECKY:

I remember. Yeah, I would be surprised if it doesn't pass this year, I think, when they come back. Are you in agreement on that?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I would say it better. I mean, this is the country of innovation. This is the country of opportunity. We already passed the Genius Act, which is about dollar backed stable coins, which literally is making the U.S. dollar available to people who haven't had access all around the globe. But in order for this to work, as our great chairman, French Hill, has said, passing the Genius Act without the Clarity Act is like building a bunch of cell towers without creating the cell phone first. So you've got to have both sides of the coin. This better get done this year because it's an important tool to help the U.S. economy lead the way yet again on digital assets.

BECKY:

Hey, Tom, very quickly, before we let you go, data centers are a huge issue. There's a lot of backlash that's kind of coming out against these data centers at this point. Minnesota has been a home to a lot of these data centers. You've got companies like Microsoft and Meta that are set up there. The president and other members of the administration have been kind of pushing back, saying that we need these data centers for the advancement of A.I. and not to lose out in that. Where do you come down on that as somebody who does have a lot of data centers in your homestead?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, I'm glad you brought that up, Becky, because the people that are arguing against it, there was one anecdotal story from my district where a lady stood up during a city council meeting and said, we can't have these data centers in this town. It'll change the town forever. At which point the one of the members on the council said, ma'am, we've had a data center in this town for 25 years. There is a ton of misinformation being pushed out about these. There's misinformation about the amount of water it uses. Data centers use less water than golf courses. It uses less water than restaurants. About the amount of energy it uses. You can have a ratepayer protection act so that it doesn't impact your ratepayers. And Becky, the other part is, for me, maybe where I differ from some of my colleagues, this is a local issue. This is an issue that the local authorities should be able to make this determination, but they should do it with the actual information that they should understand. This is a lot like the transcontinental railroad. When they were building the transcontinental railroad, every town wanted a depot in their town because they knew that that was going to improve commerce. It's the same thing with data centers. Data centers are now and they're the future if we're going to lead when it comes to computing power and AI and everything else. Don't let the 21st century leave you behind.

BECKY:

Majority Whip Tom Emmer. Tom, thank you. Coming up, New York City telling public schools to pull back on their use of AI.

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